

UPrep Model United Nations 2025



ATC

Antarctic United Nations Treaty Crisis



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Table of Contents

Director's Letter 3

Committee Overview 4

Crisis in Antarctica

▶ Past Action 6

▶ Current Situation 7

▶ Case Studies 8

▶ Bloc Positions 9

▶ Map 10

▶ Further Research 11

Director's Letter

Dear Delegates,

Welcome to UPrepMUN and the Antarctic Treaty Crisis Committee. My name is Noah Roth, and I'll be your director for this committee. Tensions are rising in one of the last untouched regions on Earth. Melting ice is revealing valuable resources, and the Antarctic Treaty, meant to preserve peace and science, is under pressure. As nations and global organizations scramble for power, the continent's future is up in the air. This committee will be fast-moving and unpredictable. You'll need to think critically, act decisively, and navigate shifting alliances.

If you have any questions before the conference or just want to chat about the topic, feel free to reach out. I'm looking forward to seeing how you shape this crisis.

All the best,

Noah Roth

Director, Antarctic Treaty Crisis

UPrepMUN 2025

Committee Overview

Signed in 1959 and enforced from 1961, the Antarctic Treaty marked a rare moment of Cold War cooperation, establishing the continent as a demilitarized zone dedicated to peace and scientific research. It froze all territorial claims, banned military activity and nuclear testing, and promoted international transparency through inspections. Over time, the Treaty expanded into a broader system that addressed marine life conservation and environmental protection, most notably through the 1991 Madrid Protocol.

Despite its success, the Treaty has long depended on mutual trust, lacking any central enforcement body. While it kept Antarctica peaceful for over six decades, unresolved sovereignty claims, advancing technology, and growing global interest in the continent's strategic and resource potential now pose serious challenges. As the line between science and strategy blurs, the system built to prevent conflict may be facing its most serious test yet.

The background of the image features a stylized, symmetrical house roof shape. The roof is composed of two main sections, each with a dark purple outer layer and a lighter purple inner layer, meeting at a central peak. The entire graphic is set against a solid dark purple background.

Crisis

Past Action

Over the past six decades, the Antarctic Treaty System has been tested by a range of political, logistical, and strategic tensions—none of which have broken the peace, but many of which have strained it. While no military conflict has taken place on the continent, there have been recurring disputes over the scope and purpose of national activities, particularly in areas where territorial claims overlap or where new infrastructure has appeared without clear notice.

Some states have pushed the boundaries of the Treaty's provisions, using military personnel or dual-use equipment for ostensibly scientific purposes. Others have expanded their logistical footprints aggressively, building permanent bases in remote or strategically located regions, sometimes without prior consultation. These moves have often drawn diplomatic complaints or inspection requests—tools which, while provided for by the Treaty, are limited in reach and reliant on voluntary cooperation.

Symbolic gestures and minor confrontations have also occurred. In previous decades, national flags, monuments, and even political visits have been used to assert influence in contested areas. Occasionally, access to airstrips or supply routes has been disrupted under murky circumstances, with explanations ranging from weather complications to “technical issues.” Though none of these incidents escalated, they revealed a persistent undercurrent of competition.

As more nations join Antarctic operations and technological capabilities advance, the space between science and strategy has grown less distinct. Past incidents—while often resolved quietly—reflect a trend of increasing tension beneath the facade of formal cooperation.

Current Situation

In early July 2025, a series of unexplained communication disruptions struck research stations across the northern Antarctic Peninsula. Chilean, British, and South Korean facilities reported simultaneous outages affecting satellite uplinks, GPS navigation, and internal data networks. Some stations were cut off from the outside world for several hours, and several reported localized signal interference and irregular electromagnetic activity. Crews on the ground noted the presence of unidentified low-flying aircraft during the blackouts—unmarked and flying below radar coverage.

Shortly afterward, satellite imagery revealed the rapid construction of a large new facility near the boundary between Argentine and Chilean claimed sectors. The base's design is striking: modular yet fortified, with long-range communication equipment and energy infrastructure far exceeding typical scientific needs. While Argentina has confirmed the project as a new "national research station," it has declined inspection requests and provided little information about the facility's function or the origin of the advanced equipment used in its construction.

Tensions have quietly escalated. Chilean officials have lodged formal complaints, raising concerns about potential violations of the Antarctic Treaty. Several Treaty signatories have expressed unease over the refusal to allow independent inspections, and analysts have noted increased coordination between Argentina and a powerful extra-regional state with advanced satellite and expeditionary capabilities.

Case Studies

Argentina

Argentina has maintained a presence in Antarctica since 1904, making it one of the longest-standing actors on the continent. As an original signatory of the Antarctic Treaty and a formal territorial claimant, Argentina views its presence as both a scientific commitment and a matter of national sovereignty. Its claim overlaps with those of Chile and the United Kingdom, particularly in the heavily occupied Antarctic Peninsula.

Today, Argentina operates more seasonal and year round bases than any other country. These installations are supported by military-run logistics from Tierra del Fuego, including icebreakers and aircraft, a practice permitted under the Treaty but often watched closely by observers. Symbolic gestures—such as visits by high-ranking officials and national flag placements—have occasionally drawn diplomatic attention. While Argentina emphasizes cooperation, its firm stance on sovereignty and its growing capacity have positioned it as a key, and at times controversial, player in Antarctic governance.

China

China joined the Antarctic Treaty System in 1983, later than most of the major players. However, it has rapidly grown into one of the most active and well-resourced presences on the continent. Over the past two decades, China has established numerous research stations and facilities, and has invested heavily in polar logistics, satellite coverage, and scientific programs.

While China emphasizes peaceful research and environmental study, the scale and pace of its expansion have raised questions among some signatories. Recent construction has included hardened infrastructure and long-range communication systems, possible dual-use infrastructure. Though it has not made a territorial claim, China is widely seen as asserting its long-term interests and seeking influence within the Treaty framework.

Bloc Positions

Treaty Preservers: Defending the Status Quo

United States, United Kingdom, Germany, France, Japan, Canada, New Zealand, Norway, Chile

These countries are firmly committed to upholding the Antarctic Treaty in its current form, emphasizing peace, scientific cooperation, and demilitarization. They support increased transparency and inspections to address potential violations, but are wary of drastic reforms that could disrupt the existing diplomatic balance. They will likely advocate for multilateral investigation efforts and cooperative measures to de-escalate tensions.

Emerging Powers: Taking the Opportunity to Expand

China, Russia, India, Brazil, South Africa, Turkey

These countries publicly endorse the Antarctic Treaty, but interpret its provisions with greater flexibility. These nations seek to expand their influence on the continent, often under the cover of scientific research. They are skeptical of Western dominance in Antarctic governance and may resist new enforcement mechanisms unless they have equal footing in their design.

Economic Advocates: Pushing for Access to Resources

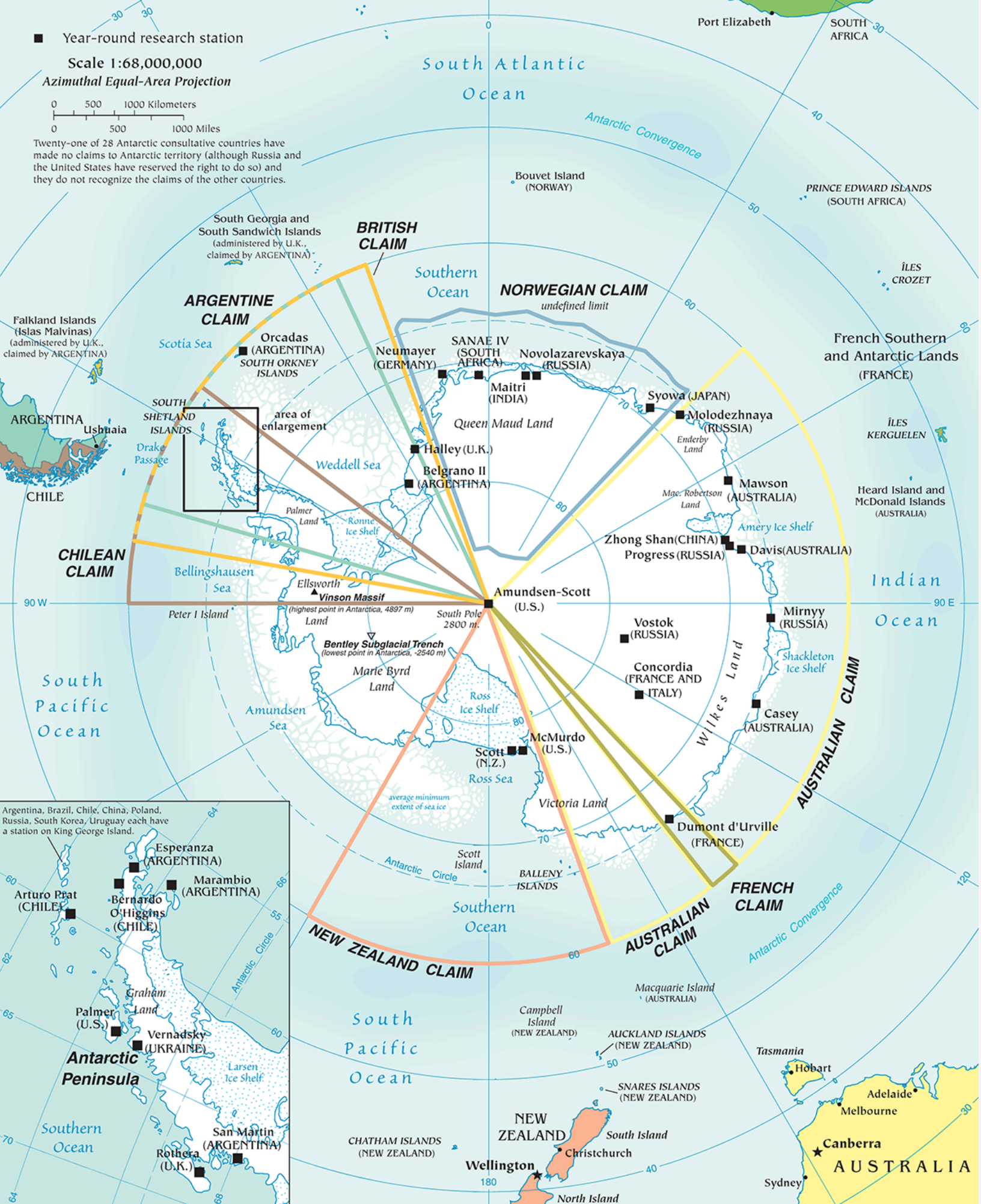
Argentina, Australia, South Korea, Saudi Arabia, Indonesia, UAE

These countries focus on the long-term economic and strategic potential of Antarctica, and they view the Treaty as outdated and in need of modernization. They advocate for revisiting restrictions on resource extraction and seek greater recognition of territorial claims. While they do not call for outright militarization, they support infrastructure development and increased autonomy over their claimed regions.

Environmental Guardians: Prioritizing the Environment over Development

Belgium, Finland, Switzerland, Iceland, Ireland

These countries prioritize strict environmental protection and the scientific value of Antarctica. They reject any militarization and oppose resource exploitation in all forms. They call for robust, independent inspections, greater transparency, and stronger international enforcement mechanisms to prevent strategic abuses. Their goal is to preserve Antarctica as a sanctuary for peace and research, untouched by geopolitical competition.



Further Research

Antarctic Treaty Secretariat

<https://www.ats.aq>

Scientific Committee on Antarctic Research (SCAR)

<https://www.scar.org>

CFR – The Antarctic Treaty Explained

<https://www.cfr.org/backgrounder/antarctica-treaty>

Wilson Center – Antarctic Geopolitics

<https://www.wilsoncenter.org/publication>

Brookings Institution – Antarctica and Global Governance

<https://www.brookings.edu/research/antarctica>

Australian Antarctic Division – International Engagement

<https://www.antarctica.gov.au>

SIPRI – China's Growing Presence in Antarctica

<https://www.sipri.org/commentary>